CPL Check Ride Preparation Checklist

Your Complete Guide to Passing Your Commercial Pilot Check Ride

SECTION 1: PHYSICAL PREPARATION (3 Days Before)

☐ Sleep at least 7 hours (non-negotiable)

Why it matters: A fatigued brain flying a commercial maneuver is completely different from a rested one.

How to do it:

- Go to bed early (3 nights before)
- Avoid screens 1 hour before bed
- Aim for 7-8 hours minimum

> 💡 *I slept 8 hours the night before my check ride. Best decision ever.*

☐ Eat a proper meal

Why it matters: Your brain and body need fuel. Hungry pilots fly poorly.

How to do it:

- Eat balanced meals (protein, carbs, veggies)
- Avoid heavy foods that make you sluggish

- Eat on time (don't skip meals)

> 💡 *I had oatmeal with fruit and coffee 2 hours before my check ride. Perfect fuel.*

☐ Hydrate well throughout the day

Why it matters: Dehydration causes brain fog, anxiety, and poor decision-making.

How to do it:

- Drink water consistently (not all at once)
- Avoid excessive energy drinks
- Bring water bottle to airport

> 💡 *I drank ~2 liters of water the day before. Felt sharp.*

☐ Avoid excessive caffeine

Why it matters: Too much caffeine = jitters, anxiety, poor focus.

How to do it:

- Limit to 1-2 cups of coffee/tea
- Avoid energy drinks the day before

- No caffeine after lunch

> 💡 *Normal coffee is fine. Just don't overdo it.*

SECTION 2: MENTAL PREPARATION (2 Days Before)

☐ Review ACS tolerances for every required task

Why it matters: The Airman Certification Standards (ACS) is your ENTIRE roadmap.

Key tolerances to memorize:

- Altitude: ±100 ft
- Airspeed: ±10 kts
- Heading: ±10°
- Bank angle: ±5°

> 💡 *I taped tolerances to my kneeboard. Examiner was impressed.*

☐ Study systems and procedures thoroughly

Why it matters: The oral exam will ask you to EXPLAIN systems, not just define them.

How to do it:

- Study your aircraft's systems deeply
- Understand WHY things work the way they do
- Be able to explain to a non-pilot
- Practice explaining out loud

> 💡 *Examiner asked me to walk through fuel imbalance scenarios. I had to THINK, not memorize.*

☐ Do a final mock oral with your instructor

Why it matters: This is your dress rehearsal.

How to do it:

- Schedule 2-hour mock oral session
- Have your instructor ask random questions
- Don't let them go easy on you
- Get feedback on what to improve

> 💡 *My mock oral was tough. But it made the real thing feel easy.*

SECTION 3: AIRCRAFT PREPARATION (2 Days Before)

☐ Confirm AROW documents are present and current

Why it matters: Without these, you cannot fly legally.

Documents needed:

- Airworthiness Certificate (current)
- Registration Certificate (current)
- Operating Limitations (POH or AFM)
- Weight & Balance (current)

> 💡 *I confirmed AROW 2 days before and 1 day before. No surprises.*

☐ Test all avionics equipment thoroughly

Why it matters: Non-functioning avionics = problems during flight test.

What to test:

- Radio (both comm and nav)
- Autopilot and GPS/moving map
- Backup instruments and lights

- Test each system twice

> 💡 *I tested all avionics the day before. Found one radio acting weird and fixed it.*

SECTION 4: DAY-OF PREPARATION (Check Ride Day)

☐ Pack all required documents

Why it matters: You cannot do a check ride without legal documents.

Pack these items:

- ✓ Pilot Certificate (current)
- ✓ Medical Certificate (current)
- ✓ Government-issued Photo ID
- ✓ Logbook and Endorsements

> 💡 *I packed everything night before and checked again morning-of. Zero stress.*

☐ Do thorough preflight with focus

Why it matters: This sets the tone for your entire check ride.

How to do it:

- Use your aircraft's preflight checklist
- Move SLOWLY and DELIBERATELY
- Check every single item
- Narrate what you're checking

> 💡 *My examiner watched my entire preflight. Slow, thorough checking impressed him.*

BONUS TIPS FOR SUCCESS

General Tips:

- ✓ Sleep well (most important)
- ✓ Stay calm (easier said than done, but possible)
- ✓ Fly the plane first (always)
- ✓ Don't memorize (understand instead)
- ✓ Ask for clarification (professionalism)
- ✓ Be yourself (not fake)

Common Mistakes to Avoid:

- ✗ Rushing preflight
- ✗ Over-studying last minute
- ✗ Staying up late night before
- ✗ Being defensive with examiner
- ✗ Guessing instead of asking
- ✗ Forgetting to fly the airplane
- ✗ Over-communicating on radio

> ***Final Thoughts***
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> *"The check ride doesn't test whether you can fly well on your best day. It tests whether you fly like a professional on a completely ordinary one."*
>
> *Train to be the pilot the ACS describes — and the check ride will take care of itself.*

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Use this checklist to prepare for your CPL check ride. Good luck! 🛫